

6

• summary & chart

In Chapter 1, I said that one way we might think of metaethics is as the subdiscipline of philosophical study of ethics that seeks to answer questions in other areas of philosophy, such as metaphysics, epistemology, philosophy of language, and philosophy of mind *as they apply to ethics*. We have now explored the four main theoretical traditions. Throughout this book, we have understood the four main theories both in terms of their commitments along various dimensions of metaethics and in terms of choice points that are represented in Figure 6.1 (which is a slight enhancement of Figure 1.1).

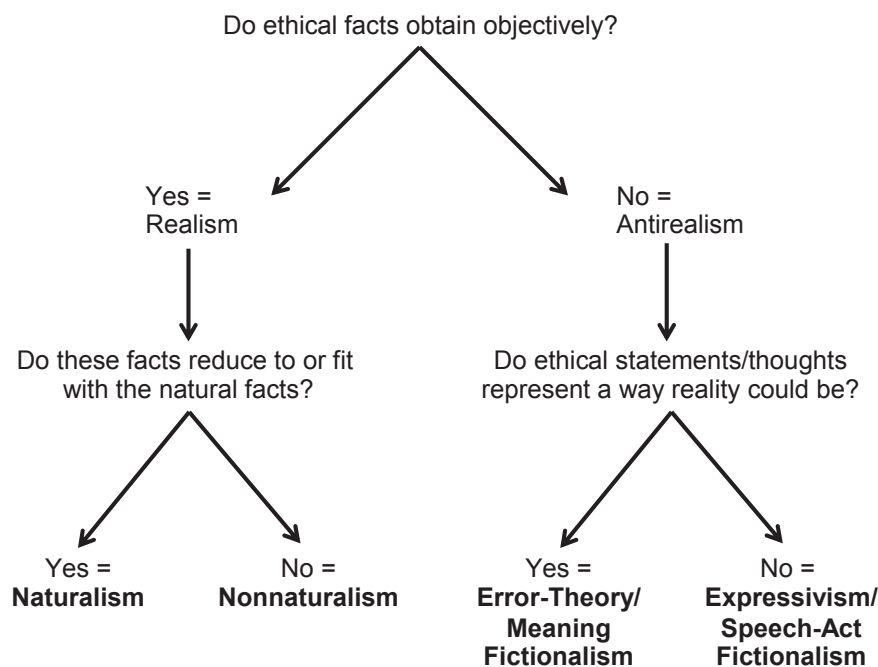


Figure 6.1 Traditional metaethical theories

We are now in a position to generate a chart, separating these theories along four dimensions. The goal of this chapter is to develop this chart in order to put you in a position to think carefully about which of these views you find most attractive, by weighing the various costs and benefits of each theory.

Key Point: The main methodology of metaethics is *theoretical cost–benefit analysis*. This means that deciding which metaethical theory you find most attractive will often be a matter of weighing the theoretical benefits of a theory in metaphysics, epistemology, philosophy of language, and philosophy of mind against its theoretical costs in these areas, and then comparing the result to competing theories.

• THE FOUR MAIN AREAS

To develop the chart, I will go back over some of the same ground we’ve covered before but in a different order and with a more general perspective.

Metaphysics

Recall that the metaphysical issues that come up in metaethics are about whether ethical facts really do objectively obtain and, if any do, what they are like. In Chapter 1, I suggested the main theoretical traditions can be first categorized into realist and antirealist theories, based on their views about the reality of objective ethical facts. Assuming, for example, that murder is wrong, a realist will say that this is a fact that objectively obtains: the wrongness of murder is just as real as the solidity of stones. Antirealists, on the other hand, deny that reality really contains objective ethical facts. They might still *say* that murder is wrong, for example, but they’ll go on to argue that this statement is either literally false or the expression of some noncognitive attitude such as condemnation.

So there’s a sense in which it’s only the realists that have further metaphysical questions to answer. Since they believe that ethical facts objectively obtain, we can ask them what these facts are like. Regarding this question, we’ve observed an initial two-way split among theories. First, convinced of the “autonomy” of ethics compared to empirical observation of the world, nonnaturalists argue that ethical facts are *sui generis*—of their own kind, not classifiable as a kind of natural fact (nor as a kind of supernatural fact). This raises important questions about the apparent supervenience of the ethical on the natural. In contrast, naturalists argue that ethical facts reduce to or can otherwise be recognized to fit among recognizably natural facts. This raises important questions about how to make that fit work.

We might start the chart with Table 6.1.

Table 6.1 Four metaethical traditions with metaphysics

	Metaphysics
Nonnaturalism	Realist Nonnatural
Expressivism	Antirealist
ET/Fictionalism	Antirealist
Naturalism	Realist Natural

Epistemology

I have placed less focus on epistemology than metaphysics in the preceding chapters, but it raises important issues that often go hand-in-hand with metaphysical issues. For if you claim that facts of a particular kind obtain, it's reasonable to ask you how someone (like yourself) might come to know one of these facts to obtain. How, for example, do we know whether Manning's leaking classified documents was morally wrong? This epistemological issue poses one of the biggest challenges for nonnaturalists, since they think ethical facts are *sui generis*, i.e. a special kind of fact that is unlike other facts with which we are familiar. Because of this, nonnaturalists generally posit a special faculty by which we come to know ethical facts—this is usually called “intuition,” but its relation to what we would ordinarily call intuition is debatable. Some nonnaturalists try to assimilate our knowledge of ethical facts to other things we know through the faculty of understanding or through reflection on how things seem to us pre-theoretically. However, it is unclear whether these projects can be carried off plausibly, which would leave ethical knowledge as *sui generis* as ethical facts. In any case, although there may be exceptions to this rule, nonnaturalists usually endorse an intuitionist moral epistemology.

QUI: Is it a cost or a benefit of nonnaturalism that it requires something like an intuitionist moral epistemology?

By contrast, while naturalists could in principle endorse an intuitionist epistemology, they don't have to and they tend not to. This is because naturalists maintain that ethical facts fit among natural facts, i.e. the sorts of facts we ordinarily come to know by some combination of empirical observation, scientific testing and theorizing, and reflection. Different naturalists place more and less stress on each of these various ways of coming to know a fact, depending on their specific account of what the ethical facts are like. For example, a posteriori naturalists might lean on an analogy with our knowledge of complicated facts about biology or chemistry, which would lead them to stress observation and scientific testing and theorizing. By contrast,

network-style a priori naturalists leaning on our ability to keep track of the different nodes of a network of related concepts might stress reflection, especially reflection on how our various ethical concepts fit together and what kinds of things could satisfy them. Either way, most naturalists work with some combination of an empiricist and coherentist picture of moral knowledge, whereby the justification for our moral beliefs derives from their overall coherence in a web of observations and reflections.

Antirealists such as expressivists and error-theorists/fictionalists deny that there are ethical facts, so initially they are off the hook when it comes to telling us how one could come to know such facts. In most cases, philosophers adopt this position because they are skeptical of our ability to know ethical facts as they are construed by realists. That is, if ethical facts are thought to be *sui generis* nonnatural facts, an antirealist might be skeptical that we could ever know them (maybe because she is skeptical that there is such a thing as the faculty of moral intuition). Or, similarly, if ethical facts are complicated natural facts that involve something like the instantiation of a homeostatic cluster of properties, or the unique fulfillment of the node in a complex network of interconnected concepts, the antirealist might be skeptical that we could ever know them.

Nonetheless, that doesn't change the fact that ordinary people commonly *talk about* ethical knowledge. So even if antirealists are off the hook for explaining how it is that we track ethical facts, considered as somehow out there in reality, they still owe us some account of what's going on when ordinary folk talk about knowing, e.g., that murder is wrong. Unless the antirealist wants to say that claims to know something like this are mistaken or nonsensical, she needs to come up with some non-tracking account of ethical knowledge. It's unclear whether this should be counted as an "epistemology" for antirealists; and there is no unified thing that antirealists say. Sophisticated expressivists tend to develop a quasi-realist story about this issue. Fictionalists tend to stress the analogy with knowledge of other fictions.

In any case, we can use the above reflections to extend the chart with Table 6.2.

Table 6.2 Four metaethical traditions with metaphysics and epistemology

	Metaphysics	Epistemology
Nonnaturalism	Realist Nonnatural	Intuitionist
Expressivism	Antirealist	Skeptical or Quasi-realist
ET/Fictionalism	Antirealist	Skeptical or Fictionalist
Naturalism	Realist Natural	Empiricist/ Coherentist

Philosophy of language

The main issue for metaethics from the philosophy of language is whether ethical sentences are representations of a way reality could be. This question forces a different grouping: Error-theorists/fictionalists agree with nonnaturalists and naturalists that ethical sentences, when literally construed, represent a way reality could be. It's just that error-theorists/fictionalists typically deny that basic ethical sentences, construed literally, ever *successfully* represent reality.

QU2: Why do error-theorists and fictionalists restrict their core claim in the philosophy of language to *basic* ethical statements rather than *all* ethical statements?

The primary contrast here is expressivism, which holds that ethical statements function not to represent reality but to express noncognitive attitudes of some sort. For example, different expressivists have tried to work out the suggestions that ethical judgments are emotively laden evaluations, complex interlocking preferences and intentions, plans, or desires of some sort. Because of this view, early expressivists denied that ethical statements are truth-apt. This means that they argued that it's strictly speaking wrong to say that an ethical statement is true or false, because such utterances are really in the business of expressing noncognitive attitudes rather than representing reality. However, later expressivists have developed subtle ways of combining expressivism with a minimalist theory of truth, according to which, saying a sentence is true is basically to say the same thing as the sentence itself. If this is right, then ethical statements might be truth-apt but still expressive of noncognitive attitudes rather than representational of reality.

Key Point: Expressivists are antirepresentationalists about ethical language; the other theories are representationalist.

This means we can further extend our chart with Table 6.3.

Table 6.3 Four metaethical traditions with metaphysics, epistemology, and philosophy of language

	Metaphysics Epistemology		Language
Nonnaturalism	Realist Nonnatural	Intuitionist	Representationalist Truth-apt
Expressivism	Antirealist	Skeptical or Quasi-realist	Antirepresentationalist Not truth-apt (or Minimalist)
ET/ Fictionalism	Antirealist	Skeptical or Fictionalist	Representationalist Truth-apt
Naturalism	Realist Natural	Empiricist/Coherentist	Representationalist Truth-apt

Philosophy of mind

The final main area of metaethics we have been discussing is the philosophy of mind (especially as it connects to action theory and moral psychology). Here, the initial division is the same as in the philosophy of language. Realists (of both nonnaturalist and naturalist stripes) accept that the mental state expressed by an ethical judgment is cognitive or, as we called it before, “belief-like.” This means that these thoughts are about a way reality could be; and as realists, these philosophers accept that some such beliefs are *true*. Error-theorists and fictionalists tend to accept the first part of this: moral thought is cognitive. But they deny the second part: atomic moral thoughts are never literally true but rather based on some sort of ontological error or covertly fictional in some way. The contrast, again, is expressivism. On this view, the mental state expressed by an ethical judgment is noncognitive or, as we put it before, “desire-like.”

This division between cognitivist and noncognitivist views of ethical thought is important for understanding where various metaethical views stand with respect to the question of motivational internalism. As we saw in Chapter 1, some philosophers have been persuaded that ethical judgments are much more tightly connected to action than ordinary beliefs about reality; hence, they endorse the idea that an ethical judgment guarantees at least some (conditional and defeasible) motivation to act. For example, if I sincerely judge that giving to charity is the right thing for me to do, the motivational *internalist* says that I will be at least somewhat motivated to give to charity (if the condition for doing so arises, though this motivation might be outweighed or undercut by my other inclinations). Motivational *externalists* deny this, arguing that although ethical judgments might often connect with our desires, intentions, and plans, there is nothing incoherent about someone sincerely making an ethical judgment and being entirely unmoved to act in its accord. Hence, metaethical theories can be divided based on where they stand on the question of motivational internalism/externalism.

QU3: Is it a cost or a benefit for a theory to be consistent with motivational internalism?

Most of the views we have considered so far are consistent with some version of the belief–desire psychology of motivation (which is often called “Humean”), which says that the mental states involved in motivation to action divide neatly into those which aim to fit the world (uncharged “representations” of how things are) and those which aim to change the world to fit them (charged “directions” of how to make things become). If we accept this and motivational internalism, there is pressure to embrace a form of expressivism. The idea is that ethical judgments are more tightly connected to motivation than beliefs about reality because they are at base desire-like rather than belief-like in their motivational potentials.

One can, however, resist this pressure. One way to do so is to argue that, because of what they are about, ethical judgments are tightly connected to having the desires needed to be motivated to act in their accord. For example, a nonnaturalist might suggest that one

of the reasons for thinking ethical facts are nonnatural is precisely that they are a special kind of fact, recognition of which tends to make one desire to act in its accord. Indeed, this way of thinking about what ethical facts would have to be like on the nonnaturalist theory is part of the reason error-theorists and fictionalists argue that there really aren't any such facts, though we speak and act as if there are (either erroneously or as part of a convenient fiction). So, error-theorists and fictionalists might agree with nonnaturalists' philosophy of mind (while disagreeing with their metaphysics).

Regarding this issue, naturalists traditionally took up one of two stances. First, as we saw, some naturalists think ethical facts are ultimately facts about our own moral viewpoints or intentions considered parts of agreements for how to live together. If this is right, then the naturalist can embrace a form of internalism in a similar way to the nonnaturalist: claim that the distinctive internal connection between ethical judgments and motivation is guaranteed by what the judgment is about. Since they are partially about one's own motivational states, it is not surprising that ethical judgments are more closely associated with motivation than ordinary beliefs about reality. Second, other naturalists reject motivational internalism, arguing instead that, although there may be a normal connection between one's making ethical judgments and being at least somewhat motivated, this isn't guaranteed or distinctive of ethical judgments.

Once rejecting motivational internalism is on the table, it seems to also be available to the nonnaturalist as well. Perhaps the best response to the error-theorist's critique of nonnatural facts as "queer" (because they are intrinsically motivating) would be to argue that they are not intrinsically motivating after all. One might argue, e.g., that they are the sorts of facts that merely normally motivate (good) people who recognize them.

In light of these considerations, we come to Table 6.4 as the full version of our chart.

Table 6.4 Four metaethical traditions with metaphysics, epistemology, philosophy of language, and philosophy of mind (with optional alternative commitments in parentheses)

	Metaphysics	Epistemology	Language	Mind
Nonnaturalism	Realist Nonnatural	Intuitionist	Representationalist Truth-apt	Cognitivist Internalist (or Externalist)
Expressivism	Antirealist	Skeptical or Quasi-realist	Antirepresentationalist Not truth-apt (or Minimalist)	Noncognitivist Internalist
ET/ Fictionalism	Antirealist	Skeptical or Fictionalist	Representationalist Truth-apt	(Cognitivist) (Internalist)
Naturalism	Realist Natural	Empiricist/ Coherentist	Representationalist Truth-apt	Cognitivist Internalist or Externalist

• COSTS AND BENEFITS

As I explained in Chapter 1, we shouldn't expect for there to be conclusive arguments for or against any of these views. Rather, the methodology of metaethics is largely one of theoretical cost-benefit analysis. When we explored each family of theories in Chapters 2–5, I explained the sorts of considerations that its proponents cite as points in its favor—these are the purported theoretical benefits—but I also explained the sorts of considerations that its opponents cite as points against it—these are the purported theoretical costs. By developing a chart of these theories' answers to some of the main questions of metaethics, I hope to put us in a position to begin to weigh such theoretical costs and benefits. Ultimately, however, weighing these costs and benefits against one another is a difficult task that students of metaethics must do for themselves, as one's views about how much each cost and benefit “counts” can reasonably vary.

Given the chart above, there are two ways we might try to proceed. First, we might try to find some independent way of assigning “plausibility points” at each cell of the chart and then try to add them up for each theory, assessing in the end which theory is most plausible. In practice, however, it tends to be very near to impossible to get working metaethicists to agree on relative plausibility points for, e.g., an intuitionist ethical epistemology or a naturalist metaphysics. So, second, we might instead trace out various “dialectical paths,” beginning with one of the views about metaphysics, epistemology, language, or mind that we find plausible. In doing so, we'll come to see how easy or hard it is to develop a full metaethical view in light of various objections and alternatives at each sector of the chart. This is the more usual methodology of metaethics.

For example, if one is strongly committed to the representationalist view of moral language, then the expressivist proposal will seem to carry heavy costs that could be outweighed only by very significant benefits on the other side. Maybe strong commitments to motivational internalism plus Humeanism about the psychology of motivation would incline someone in this position to seriously consider one of the relativist versions of naturalism that promises to make sense of these things within a representationalist conception of language. However, if one finds the relativist/subjectivist implications of such positions unpalatable, one might be forced to reopen the question about whether representationalism is correct about moral language.

Instead, one might start out strongly skeptical of the reality of anything but the natural facts. If so, then the nonnaturalist proposal will seem to carry heavy costs that could be outweighed only by significant benefits on the other side. Maybe in this case a commitment to a non-skeptical stance on ethical facts will lead one also to rule out error theory and fictionalism. This will leave expressivism and naturalism. The former requires some special story about what we're up to when we talk about moral knowledge, assuming that ethical judgments aren't beliefs about the way reality is but rather noncognitive attitudes. If one doubts such a story can be made to work, that will incline one to try to articulate and defend a version of naturalism. Here, which version one favors will then depend on whether one finds the arguments for motivational internalism compelling and what one thinks the best moral epistemology is.

Those are just a couple of examples of how we can use the chart above to trace a variety of dialectical paths, starting with one's commitments in one of the columns through one's views about other issues to the type of view one finds most plausible. Fully understanding metaethics requires not just understanding each sector on this chart, but also understanding how one traces these various paths.

It's worth mentioning one further complication regarding costs and benefits. It's controversial among metaethicists and philosophers more generally whether there can be *practical* costs and benefits for a metaethical theory. For example, some think that the error theory carries the cost of disenchanting ethics and thereby making people who believe in it less likely to behave well, which would have obvious practical costs. Could this kind of consideration be a reason to abandon the error theory? Insofar as we think of metaethical theories as descriptive theories of how things are with respect to the metaphysics, epistemology, philosophy of language, and philosophy of mind as they apply to ethics, then such practical considerations would seem to be the wrong sorts of reasons for embracing or rejecting a metaethical theory. However, if we think these theories are not themselves *descriptive*, but rather *normative*, then the role of such practical costs and benefits becomes much less clear.

• CONCLUSION

In this chapter, we have reaped the benefits of the hard work in previous chapters of coming to understand the four major theoretical traditions in metaethics and how they answer questions about metaphysics, epistemology, philosophy of language, and philosophy of mind. By taking a birds-eye view of the debate, we have developed a chart of the four main theories and their characteristic stances on questions in the four main areas of metaethics. This is intended to help you to understand these theories better by helping you to distinguish one from the other with respect to various key questions. But it is also groundwork for pursuing your own evaluation of the theoretical costs and benefits of various theories and understanding how others might come to competing evaluations by taking different dialectical paths through the positions represented on the chart.

• CHAPTER SUMMARY

- Metaphysically, metaethical theories can be divided between the realist and anti-realist, where the former allows for further distinction between the naturalist and nonnaturalist.
- Epistemologically, metaethical theories can be divided between the skeptical and the antiskeptical, where the latter allows for further distinction between intuitionist and empiricist/coherentist. Those who are skeptical about knowing genuine ethical facts are usually antirealists of some sort, but even they need to develop a story of what ordinary people are up to when talking about ethical knowledge.

- In the philosophy of language, metaethical theories can be divided between representationalist and antirepresentationalist, which usually maps directly onto a distinction in the philosophy of mind between cognitivist and noncognitivist theories.
- The philosophy of mind, or more specifically action theory and moral psychology, is where things get messier. We can, however, discern general theoretical inclinations based on how well each metaethical theory coheres with motivational internalism and the Humean psychology of motivation.
- The primary methodology of metaethics is theoretical cost–benefit analysis, taking one’s intuitions in each of these four areas of philosophy and applying it to ethics in order to determine which theory carries the best balance of benefits over costs.

• STUDY QUESTIONS

- 1 Assuming one’s strongest commitment in this area is to the reality of ethical facts, what are some of the routes one might take towards settling on a complete metaethical theory?
- 2 Assuming one’s strongest commitment in this area is to a representationalist/cognitivist conception of moral language and thought, what are some of the routes one might take towards settling on a complete metaethical theory?
- 3 Assuming one’s strongest commitment in this area is to a naturalist worldview, what are some of the routes one might take towards settling on a complete metaethical theory?
- 4 Assuming one’s strongest commitment in this area is to motivational internalism, what are some of the routes one might take towards settling on a complete metaethical theory?

• ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS OF UNDERSTANDING

- QU1: It’s generally seen as a cost because there is no independent reason to think we have a special faculty of intuition, so the existence and nature of this (putative) faculty is controversial. No one denies, however, that we have intuitions about things, and recently epistemologists have paid a lot of attention to the epistemology of intuitions. So, if the nonnaturalist can explain how the faculty of moral intuition fits with this broader and less controversial notion of intuition, there may be a way to turn this cost into a benefit.
- QU2: Consider an atomic ethical statement, such as “Aggressive war is morally wrong.” This can be negated as follows: “Aggressive war is not morally wrong.” Error-theorists and fictionalists will typically think the negated sentence is *true*—not because they believe aggressive war is morally right, but because they think nothing really has ethical properties such as rightness and wrongness.

QU3: A theory's merely being consistent with motivational internalism couldn't be a cost, as the theory could also be consistent with motivational externalism. Many metaethicists are, however, persuaded by that it would be utterly weird if someone claims that an action is the morally right thing to do but has absolutely no motivation to perform the action. And this leads them to endorse some form of motivational internalism. So, if you're persuaded by that, a theory's being *inconsistent* with motivational internalism would be a cost.